With the backing of the politically timid directors, K.R. Guruswami Aiyar manoeuvred to clip VOC's wings. VOC, as we shall recall, was assistant secretary, a statutory position enshrined in the Articles of Association, a founding document of the company. Therefore, he could be removed only by an amendment to the document by a majority of shareholders. This legal technicality apart, it was his popularity that was the driving force of the company. Even if he could be removed from his position, the popular backlash would have been difficult to handle. To short-circuit this, one S.D. Krishna Aiyangar was appointed as honorary secretary and thus placed above VOC. A regular secretary could be appointed only by the shareholders in a general body meeting, and therefore, the prefix 'honorary' is only a sleight of hand. Until the last he remained only an honorary secretary.

A graduate and trained lawyer, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar had begun his legal practice in 1899: he left 'the paying profession' thinking that 'I would do some work for the country'.[21] Whatever be the path to his accession, Krishna Aiyangar was no mercenary and had deep political convictions that did not waver until the last.

The exact date of this changeover is not known. S.D. Krishna Aiyangar recalled that he was inducted a year after the company was formed, which would give a date of late 1907.[22] Considering that he toured Salem on company work at the end of August 1907, the date of his induction must have preceded it.[23] How Krishna Aiyangar was chosen, or if he had VOC's blessings are not known. But given that they travelled to Salem together, especially so soon after the change of guard, we may assume that VOC may not have had any personal reservations. However, curiously, VOC's autobiography makes no mention of him.

As long as VOC was in charge, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar barely figures in the various documents. But once VOC was removed from the scene, he came into his own, led from the front and steadied the company against the greatest odds—a story that will occupy us in the subsequent chapters. His